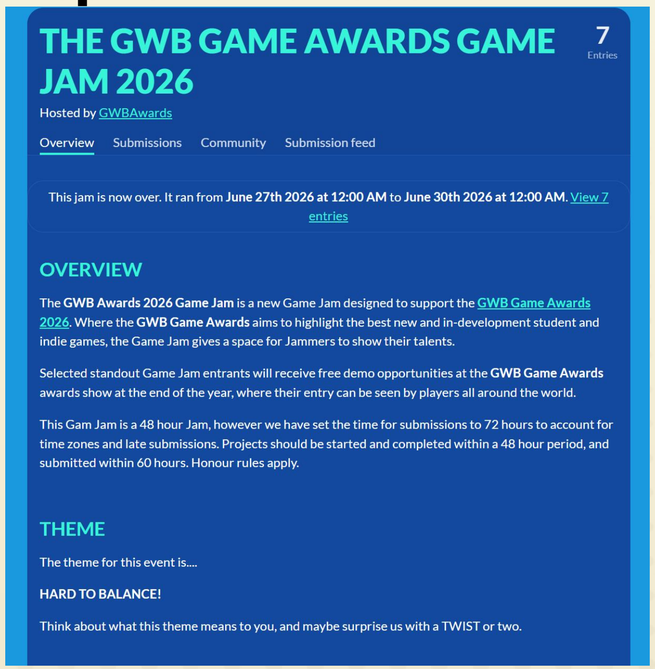

Cooperation
Xiangming Wang: Designer
Feifei Liu: Artist
Yuqi Qin: Programmer
BALANCE
or
BE BAKED
Video Link: https://youtu.be/IpVIgaPcLJE
Game Link: http://apieceoftoast123.itch.io/balance-or-be-baked
Game Overview:
Balance Be Baked is a 2D defense game where players mix flour and water to create dough of varying firmness, bake it into bread, and throw it at matching enemy types to stop them from advancing.

Early-Stage Brainstorm

Inspiration & Ideation



THE GWB GAME AWARDS GAME JAM 2026

7 Entries

Hosted by GWBAwards

Overview | Submissions | Community | Submission feed

This jam is now over. It ran from **June 27th 2026 at 12:00 AM** to **June 30th 2026 at 12:00 AM**. View 7 entries

OVERVIEW

The **GWB Awards 2026 Game Jam** is a new Game Jam designed to support the GWB Game Awards 2026. Where the **GWB Game Awards** aims to highlight the best new and in-development student and indie games, the Game Jam gives a space for Jammers to show their talents.

Selected standout Game Jam entrants will receive free demo opportunities at the **GWB Game Awards** awards show at the end of the year, where their entry can be seen by players all around the world.

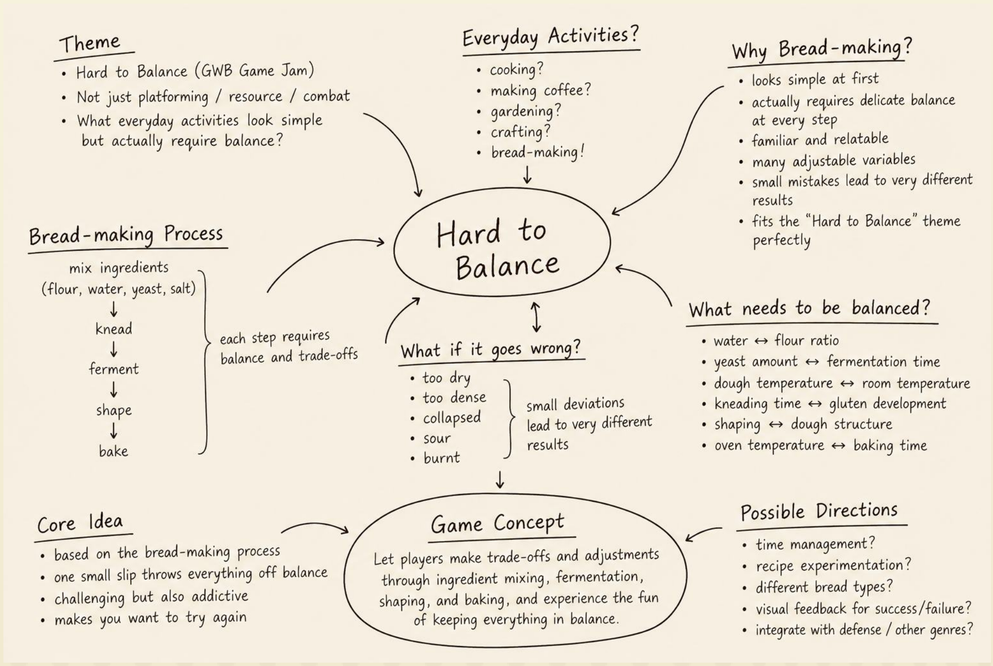
This Gam Jam is a 48 hour Jam, however we have set the time for submissions to 72 hours to account for time zones and late submissions. Projects should be started and completed within a 48 hour period, and submitted within 60 hours. Honour rules apply.

THEME

The theme for this event is....

HARD TO BALANCE!

Think about what this theme means to you, and maybe surprise us with a TWIST or two.



Theme Interpretation

Inspired by GWB Game Jam's "Hard to Balance," we explored balance in everyday life beyond conventional game mechanics.

Brainstorming

Bread-making stood out as a familiar activity requiring careful adjustments to ingredients, timing, and temperature.

Concept Development

Small changes in ingredient ratios, fermentation, or baking temperature affect dough texture and the final bread.

Gameplay Translation

Players adjust flour and water ratios to create dough of different firmness, then bake bread to defend against different enemy types.

Design Goal

Through experimentation, quick adjustments, and learning from mistakes, balance becomes an ongoing challenge that keeps gameplay playful and replayable.

Reference





This project draws inspiration from the witty lane defense of Plants vs. Zombies and the tactile, high-pressure chaos of Overcooked. One asks you to hold a line against waves of approaching monsters, while the other rewards precision in the heat of the moment, and together they turn the humble craft of baking into an unexpectedly exciting last stand.



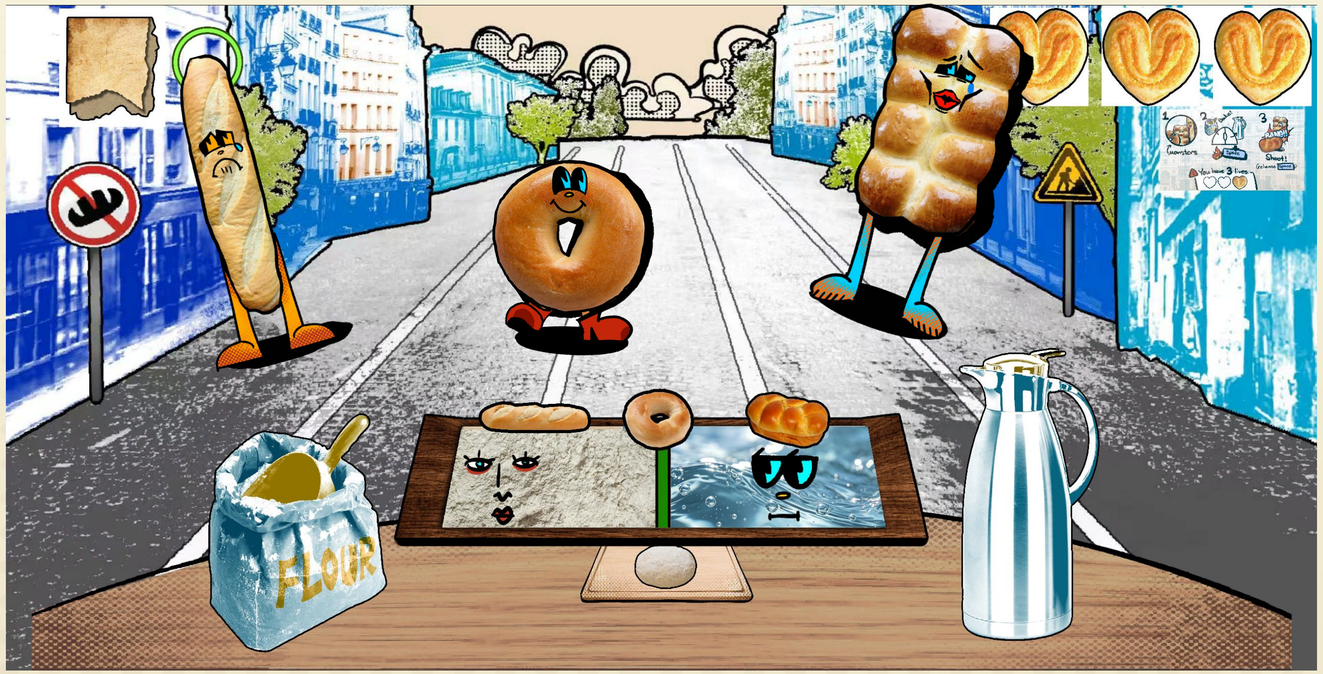


Players take the role of a pastry chef defending against approaching monsters. Through pixel art, the game blends cozy bakery charm with playful combat. Players mix flour and water to achieve the right consistency, bake their dough into bread, and throw it down five lanes, experiencing the satisfaction of turning careful preparation into a well-timed defense.

Game Mechanics

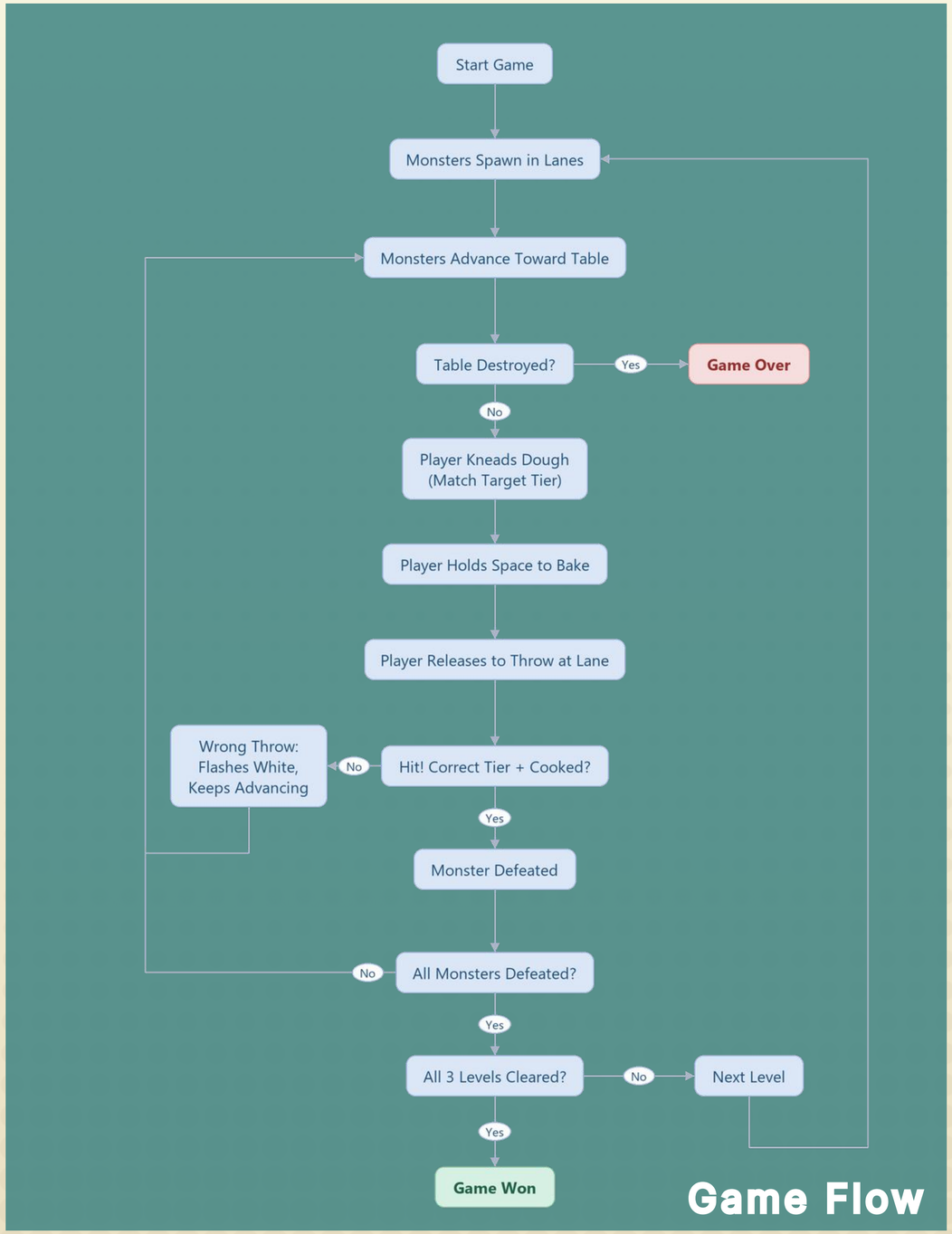
Core Mechanic

Monsters spawn randomly across 5 lanes, and players need to move the mouse cursor onto different lanes to attack them.



Kneading (The Dough)

- Left-click to add flour — the dough gets harder, and the indicator slides toward the "hard" end of the bar.
- Hold right-click to pour water — the dough gets softer, and the indicator slides back toward the "soft" end.
- The bar has three zones: Softest, Medium, and Hardest. Wherever your indicator overlaps most is your bread's current consistency.
- Each monster is weak to exactly one of the three. Match it and you've got a weapon; miss it and your loaf is harmless against that monster.

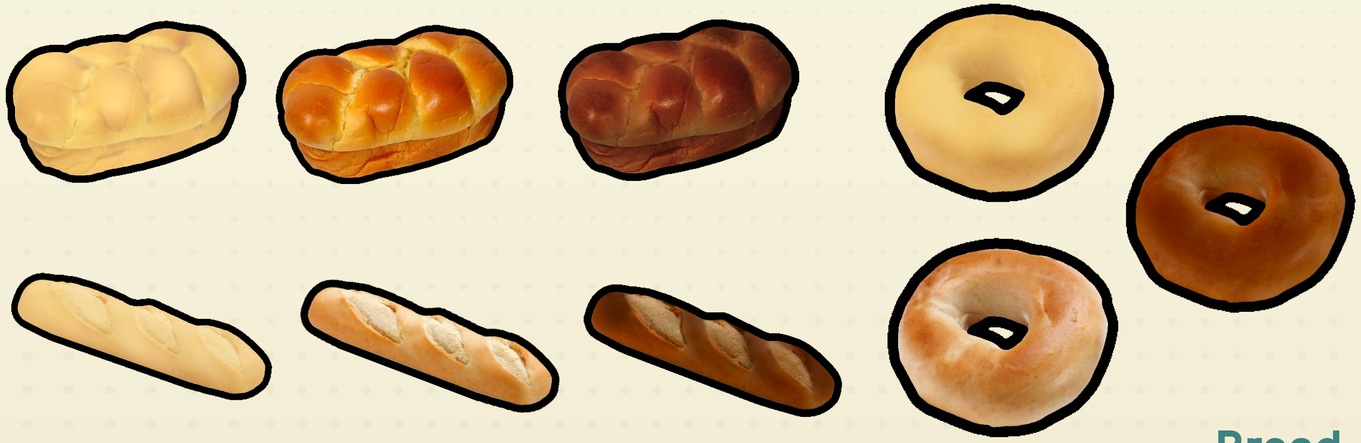


Art Showcase





Game Scene



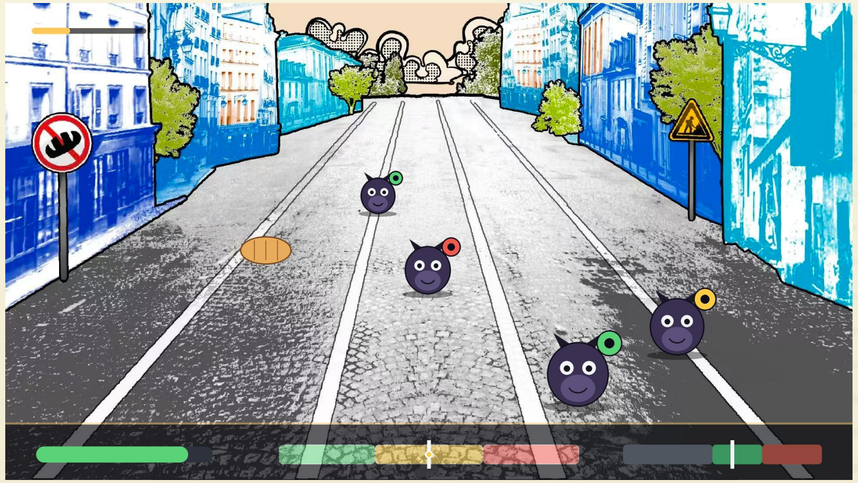
Bread





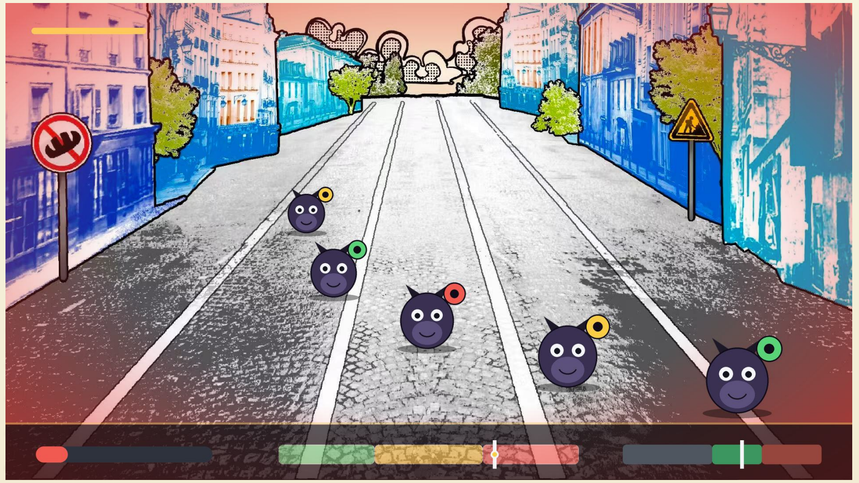
Flour & Water Animation

Test & Iteration



The First Test shows normal gameplay — four monsters spread across the lanes with coloured rings for dough type, three bars for table health, dough ratio and baking heat, and a loaf in flight — to check that the core UI reads clearly;

The Second Test shows the late-game danger state — five monsters closing in, table health down to 18% and turned red, baking still in the green window, plus a red vignette — to check that the same HUD stays readable and communicates danger under pressure.





ME

How did you find the core gameplay?

Mixing, baking, and throwing bread is fun, but managing five lanes while timing each bake feels overwhelming.

What would improve the experience?

A slightly wider baking window and distinct feedback for each mistake would help me learn and react with more confidence.

Was anything confusing during combat?

When a monster flashed white and kept moving, I couldn't tell whether I'd used the wrong dough or missed the baking window.



Play Tester

Summary
The feedback highlights an enjoyable mix-bake-throw loop, but managing five lanes alongside precise baking creates excessive pressure. Similar feedback for different mistakes also makes failures difficult to understand. Future improvements will focus on a more forgiving baking window and distinct visual and audio cues for incorrect dough and missed timing, helping players learn while preserving the challenge.